



COMMISERATIONS: Chief Minister Reddy (R) visits an injured commando

cover to the rescue teams of the Indian Navy that dived into the reservoir in search of bodies. The attack has, however, raised questions on the planning, vigilance and leadership of the requisite ranks during operations. There have been allegations of sheer complacency considering the force's impressive track record. Its performance had prompted other states to create similar commando forces to take on the Maoists in jungle warfare.

Raised first in 1989 with just 500 men, the Greyhounds has had few losses of commandos—barely 20—during anti-Maoist operations. Strapping young constables, who volunteer from the state police, are put through rigorous training for three months at its school in Hyderabad and at the

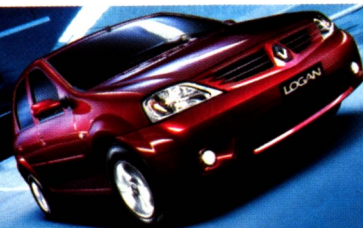
National Security Guards' school at Manesar in Haryana before they are enlisted for three years as a commando. It costs the state exchequer at least Rs 12 lakh to hone a constable as a commando. Thereafter, they spend at least 15 days a month in the woods, living off food from backpacks and getting 60 per cent of their basic pay, depending on their rank, as incentive. Their competence in undertaking sustained and systematic field operations in inhospitable jungles has stood the test of time. The Greyhounds, along with the Subsidiary Intelligence Branch, which was formed to gather information exclusively about the Maoists, has penetrated the Naxal

network and eliminated their key leaders, weakening their influence in Andhra Pradesh in the last two decades. Feeling the heat, the militants moved to the contiguous areas in Orissa and Chhattisgarh for elbow room in the hope that they cannot be tailed.

"The Greyhounds commandos are prepared for sacrifices and a couple of incidents like this will not cow them down or help the Maoists. They will now take them on with greater resolve," said an incensed state home minister, K. Jana Reddy though he admitted that using the motor launch instead of relying on their time-tested practice of trekking proved to be costly. His government has decided to offer a 200-sq yard plot, government job to an eligible member of the slain policemen's families and free education to their children apart from compensation between Rs 5 and 10 lakh, depending on the rank of the dead commando. Orissa Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik too has announced a grant of Rs 2 lakh each to the families of the dead.

A war of words, however, has ensued between the two states after Reddy blamed the other state's poor intelligence and policing for the incident. Orissa has viewed his observations as a blame game over the attack and has described it as the outcome of a major tactical blunder by the Greyhounds. "Had they taken precautions like travelling in smaller groups instead of going on a single boat, the tragedy would have been minimised," argued T.K. Mishra, Orissa's home secretary. After the tirade, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y.S.R. Reddy sought to downplay the row by saying, "this is a stray but major incident, which has exposed the lack of coordination between the states and the need to fight as a team". Though, inter-state coordination and information-sharing have made a huge difference in combating the Maoists, the chief minister's words merely underline the fact that still a lot remains to be done to combat the Naxal menace. ■

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